



Glossary of Musical Terms and Symbols

Accidentals

In music, an accidental is a note that is not a member of the scale or mode indicated by the key signature.

In musical notation the following symbols (among others) mark such notes. These symbols are also called accidentals:

sharp sign - raises the pitch by a semitone (half step/half note)

♮ natural sign - cancels a flat or sharp from either a preceding note or the key signature

♭ flat sign - lowers the pitch by a semitone (half step/half note)

BPM

Beats per minute.

Key Signature

The key signature refers to the arrangement of sharp or flat signs on particular lines and spaces of a musical staff to indicate that the corresponding notes, in every octave, are to be consistently raised (by sharps) or lowered (by flats) from their natural pitches.

Key signatures are referred to by the sound they create. Major keys are typically associated with bright, happy sounds, while minor keys are typically thought of as dark and moody.

Metronome

A metronome is a mechanical or electrical device that marks time through repeated clicking sounds, at an adjustable pace or BPM (beats per minute). Musicians use it to keep a steady beat as they practice.

For a straightforward, easy to use, online metronome, you can't beat the Google metronome for simplicity:

[Metronome](#)



Alternatively you can download a metronome app to your phone or tablet. The following metronome apps are highly recommended:

- 7metronome
- Metronomorous
- Stage Metronome
- The Metronome by Soundbrenner
- Metronome: Tempo Lite

Octave

An octave is a series of eight notes in a musical scale. It is also used to talk about the difference in pitch between the first and last notes in a musical scale

Ornamentation

In [music](#), ornaments or embellishments are musical flourishes (typically extra notes) that are not essential to the [melody](#), but serve instead to decorate or ornament that line. Ornamentation provides added interest and variety, and gives the performer the opportunity to add musical expression to a tune. Many ornaments are performed as fast notes around a central, main [note](#).

Staff Notation

A set of five horizontal lines and four spaces that each represent a different musical pitch. This is called the staff or stave. The stave essentially functions as a music graph on which music symbols are placed.

Time Signature

Time signatures define the meter or pulse of the music and tell you how the music should be counted. Music is divided into small sections called bars or measures. The time signature indicates the number of beats contained within each bar.

The time signature is written at the beginning of the staff after the clef and key signature. Time signatures consist of two numbers written like a fraction. The top number of the time signature tells you how many beats to count. The lower number indicates the type of beat.

The most common time signatures found in traditional Irish music are 2/4, 3/4, 4/4, 6/8, 9/8 and 12/8.



Tune Types

Many different classifications of tune types exist within traditional Irish music. Each classification indicates a particular time signature and style of playing.

The most common standard tune types found within traditional Irish music are polkas, jigs (double, single and slip), reels, hornpipes and slow airs.

The tradition also contains slides, mazurkas, waltzes, planxties, marches, strathspeys, schottisches and flings. Several of these tune types originate from other genres of folk music but have found a home within the Irish music tradition.

Vibrato

Vibrato is a musical effect consisting of a rapid, pulsating variation of pitch. It is used to add expression to vocal and instrumental music by producing a stronger or richer tone.